



YOU ARE **14 WEEKS AND 6 DAYS**

176 days to go

YOUR BABY TODAY

Your baby is starting to swallow amniotic fluid more regularly: this enters the stomach (seen here as a dark circle in the center of the abdomen). The tiny bladder is also visible as a black fluid-filled structure within the lower pelvis.

“The neural tube, the basis of your baby’s spinal cord, developed in the very early weeks; now the spinal cord is fully formed.”

Nerves from your baby’s spinal cord are linked to each set of his vertebrae, but as your baby grows in length the spinal cord does not grow at the same rate.

Given this difference in growth rate, the lower tip of the spinal cord ends up lying at the mid-lumbar level, which is halfway between the hips and the lowest rib.

Below the mid-lumbar level of the spine, the nerves leaving the spinal cord have lengthened so that they still exit between the lowest vertebrae. In adult life, the cord will end slightly higher than it is at birth.

Because the spinal cord does not extend the entire length of the vertebral canal, a fluid-filled space fills the lower portion.